

User Guide.

Build chords by ear or by search, arrange them into a song, and print a lead sheet that reads like it came from a well-worn fake book.

- everything the app can do, in plain language

Misty

A

Ebmaj7 Bbm7 1. Ebmaj6 2. Abmaj7

Section A of the lead sheet for 'Misty' consists of four measures. The first measure contains the Ebmaj7 chord. The second measure contains the Bbm7 chord. The third measure contains the Ebmaj6 chord, marked with a first ending bracket. The fourth measure contains the Abmaj7 chord, marked with a second ending bracket. Each chord is accompanied by a keyboard diagram showing the notes. The musical notation is on a single staff with a treble clef, starting with a repeat sign and ending with a double bar line.

B

Am7b5 D7 Gm7

Section B of the lead sheet for 'Misty' consists of two measures. The first measure contains the Am7b5 chord. The second measure contains the D7 chord. The third measure contains the Gm7 chord. Each chord is accompanied by a keyboard diagram showing the notes. The musical notation is on a single staff with a treble clef, starting with a repeat sign and ending with a double bar line.

CONTENTS

What's inside

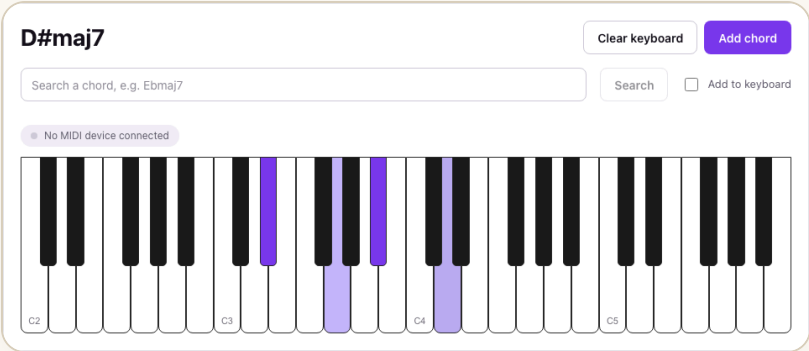
01	Building a chord	Click keys, hear each note, or type a chord name
02	MIDI keyboard input	Two-handed chords, hands-free
03	Arranging the progression	Reorder, duplicate, set lengths, edit in place
04	Sections, repeats & endings	A/B form and jazz repeat signs
05	Playing it back	Real piano sound, at your tempo
06	The lead sheet	Staff, diagrams, and the handwritten style
07	Printing, PDF & sharing	Getting a chart off the screen
08	Saving & importing	Backups, JSON, and MIDI files
09	Troubleshooting	When something doesn't sound right

i This guide covers what the app looks like in front of you. For how it's built — the code, the data model, deploying it yourself — see the developer guide that ships alongside it.

01 Building a chord

The keyboard covers four octaves — enough room for a bass note in one hand and a chord in the other. Click any key to select it; click it again to let it go.

Every note you select plays as you click it, so you always know it's the right one before you commit to it. As the selection changes, the chord name updates live above the keyboard — **Cmaj7**, a slash chord like **Dm7/F**, or, if the notes don't add up to anything recognizable, a plain **No chord match**. Nothing stops you from saving that anyway, if that's genuinely what you want on the chart.



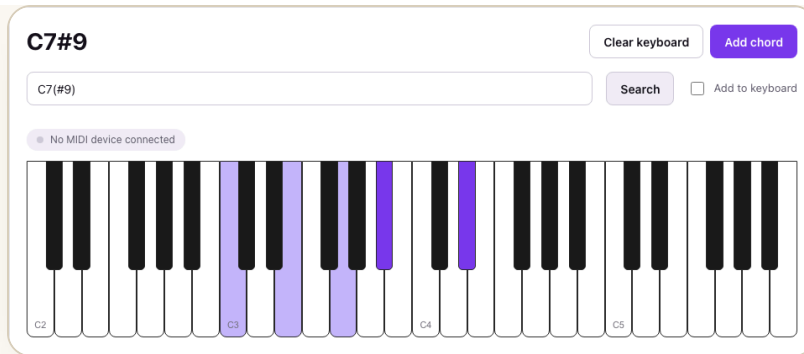
Four keys clicked in, the chord name already reading D#maj7 above them

Or skip the keys entirely — search for it

Type a chord name into the search box and press **Search**, and its notes are selected for you. From there it's just like a chord you built by hand: click any key to add or drop a note.

The search understands plain chord-symbol shorthand and ordinary spelled-out phrasing alike, and it's forgiving about how you punctuate an altered extension:

YOU CAN TYPE	OR, JUST AS WELL
Ebmaj7	Eb Major 7th
Cm7	C minor 7th chord
Bb7	Bb dominant 7
Cm7b5	C half diminished
Ab9#11	Ab9(#11) — parentheses and all
Gm7b5/Db	A slash chord over a specific bass note



C7(#9) - the parentheses, comma, or spelled-out wording all resolve the same way

- i** Tick **Add to keyboard** before you search, and the result adds to whatever's already selected instead of replacing it — useful for holding a bass note and searching the chord that goes over it.

02 MIDI keyboard input

Plug in a MIDI keyboard and open Pianograph in Chrome or Edge on a computer — Safari and iPad browsers don't support Web MIDI, so this one's a desktop feature.

Notes stay selected after you let go of the keys, so a chord no longer has to be held in place while it's added. You can play with both hands and lift them, and the chord is added by itself a moment later.

● MIDI connected: Fake Keys ☒ Add chord when I lift my hands

Connected - and the hands-free option that comes with it

WAY TO COMMIT	WHAT HAPPENS
Lift your hands	About a third of a second after the last key comes up, the chord is added and the keyboard clears — on by default, untick it to add manually instead.
Sustain pedal	Adds the chord immediately, keys still held or not.
Add chord button	Works as it always has, and leaves the keyboard as it was.

Mouse clicks never auto-add — that behavior is specific to a MIDI keyboard's hands-free flow.

03 Arranging the progression

Each saved chord becomes a card: its name, a small diagram of the notes, and the controls to reorder, duplicate, or remove it.

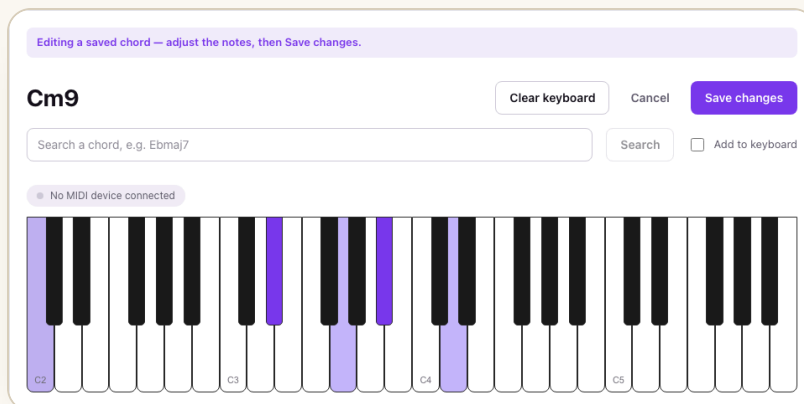
A full chorus - two sections, mixed beat lengths, and a first/second ending

The number chips set how many beats a chord lasts — two short chords can share one measure. The time signature for the whole song sits next to the tempo control.

← → move a chord, ☐ duplicates it right after itself, and × removes it. There's no undo, so export a backup first if you're not sure.

Editing a chord you've already saved

Click the chord's name or its diagram, and its notes load onto the keyboard above — the card outlines in a dashed border so you can see which one you're adjusting. Add a note, drop one, search a different voicing entirely — then **Save changes** writes it back into that same card. Its position, length, and any repeat marks stay exactly as they were.



A bass note added to Ebmaj7 - the chord re-names itself to Cm9 as you go

04 Sections, repeats & endings

The structural marks that turn a list of chords into a chart you'd recognize from a real fake book.

Sections

Add section appends an A/B/Bridge label at the end; the **§** button on any card inserts one right before that chord, for labeling a part you've already entered without walking it back one arrow at a time. Click a section's name to rename it.

Repeats and endings

Four small toggles on each card: **|:** and **:|** mark a repeat's start and end, and **1.** / **2.** mark a first or second ending. A typical setup — **|:** on the first chord of a section, **1.** on the chords of the first pass with **:|** on the last one, then **2.** on what follows. **Play progression** follows the repeat exactly, and the lead sheet draws proper repeat barlines and bracketed endings.

i Only first and second endings are supported — no nesting, no repeat counts, no D.S. or Coda. Most standards don't need more than that.

05 Playing it back

Every note, from a single click to the whole song, plays through real piano recordings — not a synthesized beep.

► **Play progression** runs the song from the top at the tempo you set (40–300 BPM), highlighting each card as it plays and following any repeats and endings, so a repeated section sounds — and lights up — twice.

The piano samples load in automatically when the app opens; until they're ready, or if they can't load at all, a simpler synth fills in so sound never actually stops working. And as with any browser audio, the first sound only plays after you've clicked something on the page — a long-standing rule browsers use to stop pages autoplaying sound at you.

06 The lead sheet

Open the **Lead sheet** tab and the progression becomes a proper chart: a staff, a diagram and name over every chord, sections breaking into their own rows.

It's always drawn as dark ink on white paper — even in dark mode — because that's how a chart should read regardless of what your screen is doing. Give the song a title before you print or share it; the title becomes the heading, and it names the files you save too.

A handwritten option

A toggle in the lead sheet toolbar swaps the chord names for a hand-lettered font — closer to a chart that's been photocopied one too many times than to typeset text. It's just the chord names; the rest of the sheet is unchanged. Your choice is remembered, and it's one click to switch back.

Misty

A

Ebmaj7 Bbm7 1. Ebmaj6 2. Abmaj7

B

Am7b5 D7 Gm7

Default

Misty

A

Ebmaj7 Bbm7 1. Ebmaj6 2. Abmaj7

B

Am7b5 D7 Gm7

Handwritten chord names, ticked on

07 Printing, PDF & sharing

Three ways to get a chart off the screen, right from the lead sheet toolbar.

BUTTON	WHAT YOU GET
Print / Save as PDF	Your browser's own print dialog. Choose "Save as PDF" for a sharp, vector PDF — it stays crisp at any zoom.
Download PNG	An image of the sheet at twice the on-screen size, ready to drop into another document.
Share	The native iPad or phone share sheet — Messages, Mail, AirDrop, wherever you'd send it. Only appears where the browser can share files over a secure connection.

While an image is being readied you may briefly see "Preparing image..."; if it can't be created, Print / Save as PDF is the reliable fallback.

08 Saving & importing

Everything is saved automatically as you work — and everything about where it's saved is worth understanding before you rely on it.

Songs live only in the browser you built them in. There's no account and no server, so your computer and your iPad each keep their own separate copy. **Export JSON** downloads the whole song, and **Import JSON** loads it back in — on the same device to restore a backup, or on another device entirely (send the file over AirDrop or email first). **Export text** gives a plain-text chord chart for pasting elsewhere; it can't be imported back.

Starting from a MIDI file

Import MIDI reads a `.mid` file and turns it straight into a progression — built for a file of block chords (a chord-chart or fake-book export, struck together and held for a clean length), not a recording of someone playing expressively. Each group of notes that starts together becomes one chord; the time signature comes from the file, and chord names are worked out by Pianograph itself rather than trusted from the file. Check the result over card by card afterward, the same way you'd clean up any other chord.

09 Troubleshooting

The chord shows "No chord match"

The selected notes may not form a chord the app recognizes, or a note may be missing from what you meant to play. You can still save it if that's genuinely the sound you want.

I can't hear anything

Click a key or press ► first — browsers block audio until you've interacted with the page. Give the piano samples a moment to load when the app first opens.

The MIDI keyboard isn't detected

Use Chrome or Edge on a computer, allow the MIDI permission prompt when it appears, and reconnect the keyboard if something else was using it first.

A chord got added by mistake from MIDI input

Delete it with ×, or untick "Add chord when I lift my hands" if it keeps happening.

The Share button isn't there

It only appears where the browser can share files over a secure (https) connection. Download PNG or Print / Save as PDF work everywhere, no exceptions.

My songs are missing

Songs are stored per browser, not per account. If you're on a different browser or device than where you built the song, Export JSON on the original and Import JSON here is the way across.

i Tap the ? button in the app itself any time for a shorter version of this guide, right where you're working.